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The True Cost of Brightwheel: Fee Calculator

Brightwheel doesn't publish pricing. This worksheet calculates your real annual cost including processing fees, and compares flat-rate alternatives.

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- ☐ Confirm attendance dates match room records.
- ☐ Mark ratio notes that support licensing review.
- ☐ Attach subsidy claim evidence before filing.
- ☐ Keep guardian and pickup updates with the child record.

Why Brightwheel doesn't publish pricing

Brightwheel's pricing page says "contact us for a quote." This is deliberate. Quote-based pricing gives the sales team flexibility to price based on your program's size, competitive situation, and how urgently you need to switch. Two centers of the same size can end up paying very different subscription rates depending on how they negotiated.

You cannot compare total cost without getting on a sales call first. Brightwheel knows this. By the time you have a quote and have spent 45 minutes with a sales rep, you have enough invested in the process that restarting with a different vendor feels like wasted effort.

Brightwheel does publish its payment processing fees: 2.9% plus \$0.30 per credit card transaction and 0.6% per ACH transfer. These appear in Brightwheel's terms of service and payment processing documentation, not in marketing materials.

Processing fees are where Brightwheel's real cost diverges from what directors expect. Most directors think of software pricing as a flat monthly fee. Brightwheel's costs scale with tuition volume, not subscription tier. A center that grows from 30 to 60 children roughly doubles its processing fee bill. The subscription may hold steady. The processing fees will not.

How to calculate your real Brightwheel cost

Brightwheel charges 2.9% plus \$0.30 for every credit card payment and 0.6% for every ACH transfer. To calculate your monthly processing cost, you need your total tuition volume and the mix of payment methods your families use.

Worked example for a center collecting \$15,000 per month in tuition:

All credit card payments:

- 2.9% of \$15,000 = \$435
- \$0.30 per transaction: 30 families paying once monthly = \$9.00
- Monthly processing fees: approximately \$444
- Annual processing fees: approximately \$5,328

Half credit card, half ACH:

- Credit card portion (\$7,500): 2.9% = \$217.50 plus \$4.50 in per-transaction fees = \$222
- ACH portion (\$7,500): 0.6% = \$45
- Monthly processing fees: approximately \$267
- Annual processing fees: approximately \$3,204

Payment mix matters. ACH is cheaper, but many families prefer credit cards for rewards points and you cannot force the switch. Calculate both scenarios before you get on a Brightwheel sales call. That number, separate from whatever subscription price they quote, is your baseline for comparison.

Calculate your processing fees by program size

Use the scenario closest to your program size, then adjust for your actual tuition volume and payment mix.

15-child center, \$8,000/month tuition (typical in-home daycare or small group care; 15 families at \$533/month, 60% credit card / 40% ACH):

- Credit card volume: \$4,800 at 2.9% = \$139.20, plus 9 transactions at \$0.30 = \$2.70.
Subtotal: \$141.90
- ACH volume: \$3,200 at 0.6% = \$19.20
- Monthly processing fee: approximately \$161
- Annual processing fee: approximately \$1,932
- Add Brightwheel subscription (undisclosed; estimate \$100-200/month based on reported ranges)
- Estimated total annual cost: \$3,132 to \$4,332

40-child center, \$22,000/month tuition (mid-size licensed center; 40 families, 65% credit card / 35% ACH):

- Credit card volume: \$14,300 at 2.9% = \$414.70, plus 26 transactions at \$0.30 = \$7.80.
Subtotal: \$422.50
- ACH volume: \$7,700 at 0.6% = \$46.20
- Monthly processing fee: approximately \$469
- Annual processing fee: approximately \$5,628
- Add Brightwheel subscription (estimate \$200-400/month for a center this size)
- Estimated total annual cost: \$8,028 to \$10,428

75-child center, \$40,000/month tuition (larger licensed center near the upper end of Brightwheel's market; 75 families, 70% credit card / 30% ACH):

- Credit card volume: \$28,000 at 2.9% = \$812, plus 53 transactions at \$0.30 = \$15.90.
Subtotal: \$827.90
- ACH volume: \$12,000 at 0.6% = \$72
- Monthly processing fee: approximately \$900
- Annual processing fee: approximately \$10,800
- Add Brightwheel subscription (estimate \$300-600/month based on reported figures from director communities)
- Estimated total annual cost: \$14,400 to \$17,600

The 75-child center is paying somewhere between \$14,000 and \$18,000 per year for a platform that directors in online communities describe as requiring significant manual workaround for anything involving subsidy reconciliation or audit trail documentation.

What else gets added to your bill

Subscription and processing fees are visible. These are not.

If your center uses Brightwheel's check-in kiosks or tablets, those are separate hardware purchases or rentals, not always included in the base subscription. Onboarding assistance has been offered as a paid add-on depending on plan tier, with cost varying by contract. Directors who share quotes in online communities often describe renewal pricing and add-on costs that differ from the initial sales quote, so it is worth getting those terms in writing before you sign. Multi-site operators do not get published pricing, and some accounting software or state agency portal connections may require configuration work outside the standard subscription.

The sales quote is a starting point, not a full long-term budget. Processing fees grow with enrollment, and contract terms around renewals, onboarding, hardware, and integrations can change the total cost over time. Budget against the full contract, not just the headline subscription number.

Brightwheel vs. flat-rate alternatives

Brightwheel's cost grows as your enrollment grows. Add three families in September and your processing fee bill goes up, even if you are not using a single new feature.

Flat-rate pricing is a fixed monthly fee regardless of tuition volume. You know your software cost for the year in January.

40-child center comparison (\$22,000/month tuition, \$469/month in Brightwheel processing fees):

Platform	Monthly Subscription	Processing Fee	Monthly Total	Annual Total
Brightwheel	\$200-\$400 (estimate)	~\$469	~\$669-\$869	~\$8,028-\$10,428
PebbleDesk Center	\$50	\$0 (no per-transaction fee)	\$50	\$600
Procure (cloud)	\$129-\$299	Varies	\$129-\$299+	\$1,548-\$3,588+

For a 40-child center, switching from Brightwheel to a flat-rate platform saves approximately \$7,000 to \$10,000 per year before accounting for subscription differences. For a 75-child center, the difference runs \$13,000 to \$17,000 per year. At the high end, that is a full-time staff member's annual salary going to processing fees.

The subsidy billing gap

Processing fees measure what you pay to collect tuition from private-pay families. They say nothing about collecting from subsidy agencies, which is the real billing complexity for programs with subsidized enrollment.

Subsidy agencies, state CCDF programs, county DHS offices, Head Start grantees, do not pay through Brightwheel's payment processor. They pay via ACH from state systems, paper checks, or state portals that have nothing to do with Brightwheel.

Directors who use Brightwheel for billing and manage subsidy claims separately through state portals run two billing systems. The processing fee savings from ACH subsidy payments never materialize because those payments do not go through Brightwheel at all.

Brightwheel was built to collect tuition from parents, not to manage subsidy authorization periods, absence tracking against state limits, or attendance record formatting for state portal submission. If more than 15-20% of your enrollment is subsidized, this becomes a daily operational problem.

When you calculate your true Brightwheel cost, add the hours your director or office manager spends each month on state portal submission, authorization tracking, and subsidy reconciliation that Brightwheel does not handle. That time has a dollar value, and it does not appear in any processing fee calculation.